

Text structure - Study Guide

Recognize how ideas are organized and explain how that organization helps develop meaning.

Learning goal

Identify the relationship organizing a text or section and analyze how that structure supports the writer's explanation or purpose.

What this skill really means

Text structure is the pattern that connects ideas. Common patterns include cause/effect, problem/solution, compare/contrast, sequence, description, and claim/evidence.

Real passages can combine structures. A passage may begin with a problem, compare two possible responses, and end with evidence for one option.

The important question is not only "What structure is this?" but "How does this organization help the reader understand the writer's point?"

Structure	What it organizes	Common clues
Cause / effect	why something happens and what follows	because, leads to, results in, as a result
Problem / solution	a difficulty and a response	problem, challenge, address, solution, response
Compare / contrast	similarities and differences	both, unlike, whereas, in contrast
Sequence / process	steps or chronological order	first, next, after, finally

Structure	What it organizes	Common clues
Claim / evidence	an idea supported by reasons or facts	argues, shows, data, evidence, for example
Description / classification	features, parts, or categories	includes, consists of, types, characteristics

How exam-style questions ask it

- How is the information in the passage mainly organized?
- Which structure best describes paragraphs 2-4?
- How does the author's organization help develop the central idea?
- Why does the author present the two methods side by side?

A reliable method

1. Identify the major ideas or sections rather than individual sentences.
2. Name the relationship between those ideas in plain language.
3. Match that relationship to a structure label.
4. Check whether the structure stays consistent or changes across sections.
5. For effect questions, explain what the organization makes easier to understand, compare, evaluate, or follow.

Tips and shortcuts

- Do not choose a structure just because one signal word appears. Follow the relationship across several sentences.
- If two structures seem possible, ask which one organizes the largest amount of important information.
- For a mixed structure, identify the structure of the exact section named in the question.

Worked examples

Example 1

A science article explains that removing shoreline plants increases erosion. It then describes faster soil loss, cloudier water, and damage to fish habitat.

1. What structure mainly organizes this section?

- A. cause and effect
- B. compare and contrast
- C. problem and solution
- D. chronological biography

Answer: A

The section links one change - removing vegetation - to several results, so cause/effect is the controlling structure.

Example 2

A school report describes two lunch-line systems. For each system, it gives wait time, staffing needs, and student feedback before explaining which system performed better.

2. Why is compare/contrast useful here?

- A. It hides which system costs more.
- B. It lets readers evaluate the systems using the same criteria.
- C. It places events in historical order.
- D. It defines the word staffing.

Answer: B

Presenting the same criteria for both systems makes their similarities and differences directly comparable.

Common traps

- Choosing sequence just because events have dates, even when the main relationship is cause/effect.
- Calling a text compare/contrast because it mentions two things without actually comparing them.

- Identifying a structure correctly but giving the wrong effect.
- Assuming every informational passage follows one structure from beginning to end.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, name the exact relationship between the target wording and the larger text. Point to evidence for that relationship, not just a familiar label.

Quick check

1. A text presents a challenge, then three actions taken to address it. Which structure is most likely?
2. Why can one signal word be insufficient for identifying structure?
3. What is the difference between identifying structure and explaining its effect?

Quick check guidance

Explain the relationship in plain language before using a technical label. If your explanation works only as a summary, ask what job, purpose, perspective, or effect is still missing.